

RAJWANT RAWAT

Bengaluru, who is off to do a master's in graphic design in a British university, says, "Apart from the state-of-the-art facilities, the global exposure and cultural diversity will help me build a network of peers and professionals."

The Great Indian Student Deluge

They come from all over—big cities and small towns—and there are as many girls as there are boys. You could well blame Covid for the swell in numbers in the past year and a half. As country after country closed its doors to the marauding virus, students aspiring to study abroad had to put their plans on hold. Only when things eased in 2021 could those who had deferred admissions finally join. Others attending classes online from their home countries could finally see what the university grounds looked like.

Another factor spurring the exodus came in the form of CUET, a common university entrance test that the University Grants Commission in India mandated since last year for admission in college. Coming as it did in the shadow of the Covid disruptions and plagued by teething troubles in the first year of its implementation, it delayed the university session by some four months, throwing students into panic and uncertainty. CUET has brought the curtains down on the cut-off system that had become somewhat of a joke. Class 12 marks no longer determine which college you take admission into; CUET instead tests a student's conceptual grasp of a subject and aims to provide students with a level playing field. Earlier, students adept at rote learning and from boards that privileged it had an unfair advantage over the rest. The flip side is, with marks no longer a guarantee for admission in a good college or course, many students are unwilling to put up with the uncertainty of whether they will get the course and college of their choice.

"The Indian education system and its method of taking in students at the better universities has become very competitive," says Guwahati-based Rinjee Baruah, senior zonal counselling manager with Global Reach, a study abroad career counselling organisation. Also, as Nitina Chopra Dua, head, Career Guidance Centre, Shiv Nadar School, Noida, points out, "While the world is moving towards the test optional method, in India, we are going the test way. So, it's getting tougher for children to get admission in the colleges and courses of their choice." Quality institutes in our country offer only a limited number of seats. Last year, for instance, some 1.4 million students graduated from schools, but besides the scant intake in professional colleges, the number of seats in central universities was just 200,000. Private colleges just cannot fill the gap, mushrooming as they may well be.

Naturally, the intense competition is leaving students frazzled, and they are increasingly realising that it's far easier to get into a well-ranked university abroad than into an IIT or Delhi University. A student with

SABHAYA KANWAR, *18*
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» **GOING FOR:** Bachelor's in Economics, London School of Economics, UK

» **WHY HE WANTS TO GO**

"I feel that studying in the UK will give me several growth opportunities and expose me to new skills. It will also help me prepare better for a master's later as well as my long-term career"